

CINEMA

THE QUESTION OF GANDHI

RAJKUMAR SANTOSHI TALKS ABOUT HIS LATEST FILM AND WHY INDIAN FILMMAKERS REMAIN WARY OF CASTING THEIR LENS ON GANDHI

When Shah Rukh Khan returned to the big screen after 1,484 days, the hero he was up against for box-office glory was a real-life one: Mohandas Karamchand Gandhi. Rajkumar Santoshi's film, *Gandhi Godse-Ek Yudh*, lost the battle for eyeballs, but it didn't have as hard a run with the censors at the Central Board of Film Certification as the producers of Khan's film, Yash Raj Films, did. What Santoshi did have a tough time with was finding producers to fund his political drama due to its controversial nature, as it pitted Gandhi against his assassin in a verbal duel. "They [producers] didn't want to touch it," says Santoshi. It did not help that he did not want to "take any stars" for his first film in nine years. "Gandhi himself is a big star, Godse is immensely popular," he says.

Despite his star status, Gandhi has been largely absent from mainstream Hindi cinema in recent times. For Santoshi, it's a matter of shame that "we haven't made more films" on Gandhi. Such is the state that the first film on Gandhi that comes to most people's mind is one made by a British filmmaker: Richard Attenborough's *Gandhi* (1982). Shyam Benegal also made a film on his years in South Africa, titled *The Making of the Mahatma* (1996), while the Kamal Haasan-directed bilingual film *Hey Ram* (2000) focused on a man who blames the Partition on Gandhi and seeks revenge. However, neither of these resonated as much as Rajkumar Hirani's Munna Bhai